

1909–1926

ORIENTALISM

In the summer of 1909 the Ballets Russes (Russian Ballet), the company formed by impresario Sergei Diaghilev, first performed in Paris with great success. Shows in other European cities followed over the next 10 years and everywhere the bright colours of the ballet's sets and costumes made a huge impact – “exotic” features such as turbans and harem trousers were adapted for fashionable dressing. While Paul Poiret claimed to have used bright colours before the Ballets Russes, the French couturier, the so-called “Pasha of Paris”, is most associated with this trend. Poiret continued a long tradition of using motifs from Middle Eastern and Asian cultures in Western design that went back at least as far as the Renaissance. During the 19th century North Africa and Japan were prominent sources of inspiration and continued to be so in the 20th century. Ideas of which countries belonged to the “Orient” changed over time, but they were usually associated with a richer, freer, and more sensuous way of life.

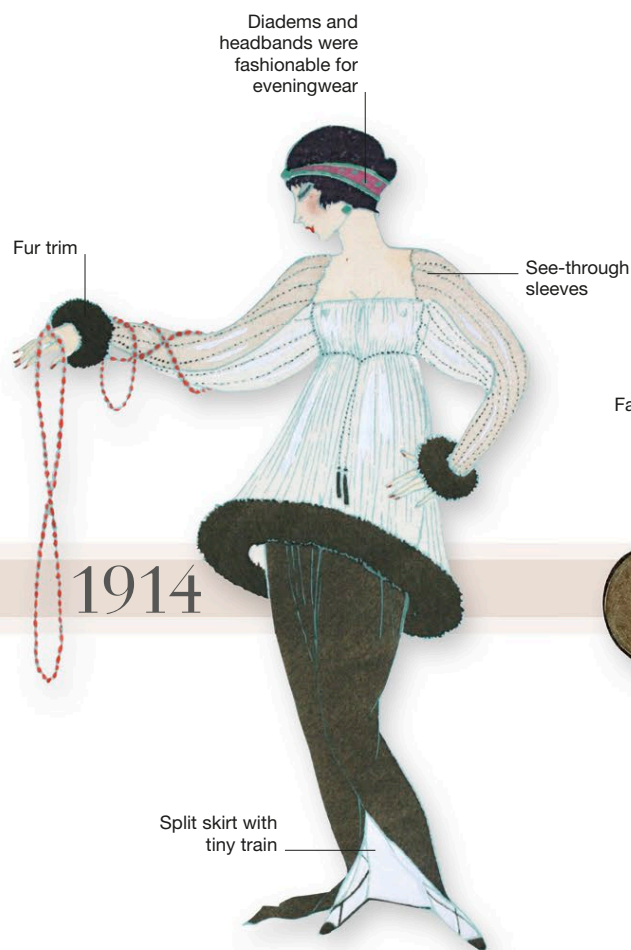


1909

Japonism The cut of this evening mantle by the House of Worth is reminiscent of a kimono and shows the enduring influence of Japan. The original founder's son Jean-Philippe, who ran the House of Worth after 1895, had studied painting, an art form in which Japonism was all the rage.

HARLEM DANCER

The identity of the woman in this 1925 photograph – titled *Dancer* and taken in the Harlem district of New York – is unknown, but she is wearing a costume similar to a Ballets Russes design. Dyed ostrich feathers tower over a headdress perhaps inspired by traditional Persian dress. Apart from the baggy trousers, her outfit is heavily embroidered with beads and spangles.



1914

Lampshade tunic After his famous Persian fancy dress party, Paul Poiret created one of his best-known designs – a tight “hobble” skirt and a lampshade tunic held out with wire. This diaphanous example is edged with black fur.



Pagoda The tiered tower design from Asia was imitated in Western architecture, interior design, and fashion. The outfit depicted in French designer Etienne Drian's fashion plate might have been fancy dress, but certain features also appeared in fashionable gowns.